Nature, for its part, is what it is—and we discover it very gradually. If our grammar and our intuition do not readily adapt to what we discover, well, too bad: we must seek to adapt them.

The grammar of many modern languages conjugates verbs in the "present," "past," and "future" tense. It is not well-adapted for speaking about the real temporal structure of reality, which is more complex. Grammar developed from our limited experience, before we became aware of its imprecision when it came to grasping the rich structure of the world.

What confuses us when we seek to make sense of the discovery that no objective universal present exists is only the fact that our grammar is organized around an absolute distinction—"past/present/future"—that is only partially apt, here in our immediate vicinity. The structure of reality is not the one that this grammar presupposes. We say that an event "is," or "has been," or "will be." We do not have a grammar adapted to say that an event "has been" in relation to me but "is" in relation to you.

We must not allow ourselves to be confused by an inadequate grammar. There is a text from the world of antiquity that refers to the spherical shape of the Earth in the following way:

> For those standing below, things above are below, while things below are above . . . and this is the case around the entire earth.[65]

On first reading, the phrase is a muddle, a contradiction in terms. How is it possible that "things above are below, while things below are above"? It makes no sense. It is comparable to the sinister "Fair is foul and foul is fair" in *Macbeth*. But if we reread it bearing in mind the shape and the physics of the Earth, the phrase becomes clear: its author is saying that for those who live at the Antipodes (in Australia), the direction "upward" is the same as "downward" for those who are in Europe. He is saying, that is, that the direction "above" changes from one place to another on the Earth. He means that what is above *with respect to Sydney* is below *with respect to us*. The author of this text, written two thousand years ago, is struggling to adapt his language and his intuition to a new discovery: the fact that the Earth is a sphere, and that "up" and "down" have a meaning that *changes* between here and there. The terms do not have, as previously thought, a single and universal meaning.

We are in the same situation. We are struggling to adapt our language and our intuition to a new discovery: the fact that "past" and "future" do not have a universal meaning. Instead, they have a meaning that changes between here and there. That's all there is to it.